

Career Roadmap: 4 LPA → 13–15 LPA

A 12-Month, Brutally Honest, Dual-Path Plan

Prepared for	Aman Kumar
Current role	Salesforce Developer Intern, Cognizant GenC
Target window	12 months from May 2026
Target CTC	INR 13–15 LPA (stretch: 18 LPA)
Paths covered	A — Salesforce + GenAI Hybrid B — SDE Pivot

This document is a working plan, not motivation. Print it. Stick it on your wall. Cross off weeks as you finish them. If you fall behind by >3 weeks, re-read the reality check on page 2 and decide whether to drop one path.

1. Reality Check (Read This First)

Cognizant GenC fresher CTC is approximately 4–4.5 LPA. Moving to 13–15 LPA inside one calendar year means a 3x jump. This is uncommon but not rare — roughly 15–25% of any GenC batch pulls it off within 12–18 months. The ones who do share four traits:

- They picked **one** high-leverage skill stack and went deep, not wide.
- They ship public artifacts — GitHub, blog posts, Trailhead badges, demo videos.
- They get certified early (signals seriousness to recruiters and HR filters).
- They start interviewing externally at month 9, not month 12.

Hard truths. Cognizant's internal hike at 1 YOE will be 8–15%. You will not reach the target by staying put. The 13–15 LPA number requires an external switch at the 12–15 month mark.

If you have less than 12 hours per week of consistent, focused study time outside work, pick Path A only. Path B requires 15–20 hours/week minimum and will burn you out if attempted half-heartedly.

2. Salary Reality (India, 2026)

Role / 1–2 YOE	Service Co. (Cognizant tier)	Mid-tier / Consulting	Product / Top-tier
Salesforce Developer	5–8 LPA	9–13 LPA	14–20 LPA
Salesforce Agentforce/GenAI +	7–10 LPA	12–16 LPA	18–24 LPA
SDE (Backend/Full-stack)	4–7 LPA	10–16 LPA	18–30 LPA
GenAI Engineer (RAG/LLM apps)	8–12 LPA	14–20 LPA	22–35 LPA

Ranges are approximate, based on Levels.fyi, Glassdoor India, and AmbitionBox data points for Bangalore/Hyderabad/Chennai. Tier-2 cities subtract ~15%.

PATH A — Salesforce + GenAI Hybrid

Highest probability of hitting 13–15 LPA. Builds on your current role. Recommended primary path.

Why this works

- You are already paid to learn Salesforce — compounding effect.
- **Agentforce** is Salesforce's biggest 2025–2026 bet. Demand >> supply in India right now.
- Adding GenAI/RAG layer makes you scarce. Pure Salesforce devs are not scarce.
- Target employers (Deloitte, Accenture, IBM iX, ZS, Salesforce India, Persistent) actively pay 12–16 LPA for 1 YOE with Agentforce + 2 certs.

12-Month Plan at a Glance

Quarter	Months	Focus	Output
Q1	Jun–Aug 2026	Crush Cognizant evals + foundation deep-dive	PD1 cleared, 1 portfolio project, all training evals passed
Q2	Sep–Nov 2026	LWC mastery + Integration patterns + first Agentforce build	PD2 prep done, 2nd portfolio project, internal recognition
Q3	Dec 2026–Feb 2027	Agentforce Specialist + GenAI stack (RAG, prompt eng, vector DB)	Agentforce cert, GenAI side-project deployed, blog series started
Q4	Mar–May 2027	Interview prep + external applications + offer negotiation	PD2 cert (optional), 3 offers in hand, switch executed

Q1 (Jun–Aug 2026) — Foundation + PD1

Goal: Pass all pending Cognizant evals. Clear Platform Developer 1 (PD1). Build 1st GitHub project.

- **Week 1–4:** Finish current eval prep (Aptitude May 8, AI/ML May 10, Salesforce May 21). Already in motion.
- **Week 5–8:** PD1 prep — Trailhead 'Prepare for your Salesforce Platform Developer I Credential' trail + Focus on Force practice exams (single best resource, ~INR 1500). Take exam end of Aug.
- **Week 9–12:** Build **Project 1** — a real-world Salesforce app on a public GitHub repo (e.g., a small CRM extension or scheduling app). Document with README + screenshots.
- **Daily rhythm:** 6:00–6:45 AM concept (Trailhead/Apex docs), 9:00–9:45 PM hands-on (build/code).

Q1 Resources

- Trailhead: 'PD1 Certification Trailmix' (free, official)
- Focus on Force: PD1 practice exams (paid, ~INR 1500, highest-ROI purchase)
- Salesforce Ben blog — PD1 exam guide
- YouTube: SFDCFacts, Sudipta Deb

Q2 (Sep–Nov 2026) — LWC + Integration + Agentforce intro

Goal: Become LWC-fluent. Master Integration. Build first Agentforce demo.

- **Sep:** Deep LWC — reactive properties, wire service, Lightning Data Service, custom events, parent-child communication. Build 5 small components.
- **Oct:** Integration deep-dive — REST/SOAP callouts, Named Credentials, External Services, Platform Events, Change Data Capture. You have notes on this already — extend them.
- **Nov:** First Agentforce build — an Agentforce agent that answers Account-related queries using a custom Apex action + Atlas reasoning. Record a 3-min Loom demo. Post on LinkedIn.
- **Project 2:** LWC + Apex + REST integration app (e.g., a Slack-Salesforce sync, or a weather widget for Service Cloud). Public GitHub.

Q2 Resources

- Trailhead Superbadges: 'Lightning Web Components Specialist', 'Apex Specialist'
- Salesforce Developer Docs: LWC Recipes (github.com/trailheadapps/lwc-recipes)
- Agentforce Trailhead trail (official, free, ~20 hours)
- Pluralsight or Udemy: 'Salesforce LWC for Developers' (any 4+ star course)

Q3 (Dec 2026–Feb 2027) — Agentforce Specialist + GenAI Stack

Goal: Become the person who can talk fluently about LLMs and Salesforce in the same sentence. Most candidates can do one or the other — not both.

- **Dec:** Agentforce Specialist cert. Study Atlas reasoning engine, custom actions, prompt templates, data cloud integration.
- **Jan:** GenAI fundamentals outside Salesforce — prompt engineering, RAG architecture, FastEmbed/sentence-transformers, FAISS vs. Pinecone vs. Weaviate, LangChain/LlamaIndex basics. Your HackerRank already touches RAG — go 5x deeper.
- **Feb:** Build **Project 3** — a RAG-powered chatbot that answers questions over Salesforce data via Einstein/Agentforce. Deploy on Heroku/Render. This is your portfolio centerpiece.
- **Throughout:** Write 4–6 LinkedIn posts. Tag #Agentforce #SalesforceDeveloper. Recruiters search these tags.

Q3 Resources

- Agentforce Specialist trail (Trailhead)
- Anthropic & OpenAI prompt engineering guides (free)
- DeepLearning.AI short courses: 'LangChain for LLM Application Development', 'Building Systems with the ChatGPT API'
- Book: 'Building LLM Apps' by Valentina Alto (concise, practical)

Q4 (Mar–May 2027) — Interview Prep + Switch Execution

Goal: 3 offers minimum. Negotiate. Switch.

- **Mar:** Resume + LinkedIn overhaul. Title yourself 'Salesforce Developer | Agentforce | GenAI' — not 'Intern'. List certs, projects with links, measurable impact.
- **Mar–Apr:** Apply to 60+ roles. Target: Deloitte (Salesforce practice), Accenture, IBM iX, Persistent, ZS, NTT Data, Capgemini Salesforce practice, Salesforce India, mid-size Salesforce consultancies (Cyntexa, Cloudkettle, AblyPro).
- **Apr:** Interview prep — LWC live coding, Apex governor limits, async patterns, Agentforce architecture questions, behavioral STAR stories.
- **May:** Negotiate. Use offers against each other. Counter every first offer once.

Realistic Outcome (Path A)

Scenario	Probability	CTC Range	Notes
Best case	20%	16–20 LPA	PD1 + PD2 + Agentforce + strong projects + lucky interview at top consulting
Expected	55%	11–14 LPA	PD1 + Agentforce + 3 projects, decent interview performance
Floor	20%	8–10 LPA	Certs done, projects mid-tier, weaker interview — still a 2x jump
Failure	5%	Stay at Cognizant	Did not execute plan; got stuck in service-co loop

PATH B — SDE Pivot (Backend / Full-Stack)

Highest ceiling, highest risk. Domain change from Salesforce to general software engineering. Pursue only if you can commit 15–20 hrs/week.

Why this is risky for you specifically

- Your DSA foundation is strings, arrays, hashmaps. No trees, no graphs, no DP. That is roughly 30% of the syllabus. You will need 6–9 months to close the gap.
- Product companies filter on DSA at the resume screen. You need ~1500 LeetCode points or 200+ problems solved to clear the bar.
- Cognizant work won't reinforce these skills — it will actively pull time away from them.
- If you don't clear product co. interviews, you end up with a diluted profile (weak Salesforce, weak SDE) and may earn *less* than Path A would have delivered.

Decision rule: Attempt Path B only if you can guarantee 15+ hours/week of focused study (LeetCode + system design + projects) for 9 months straight. Honest self-audit: have you ever sustained that for 9 months on anything?

12-Month Plan at a Glance

Quarter	Months	Focus	Output
Q1	Jun–Aug 2026	DSA foundations rebuild + 1 language fluency	200 LeetCode problems (Easy/Medium), Java or Python fluency
Q2	Sep–Nov 2026	Trees, graphs, recursion, DP intro + Spring Boot / Node basics	350 total problems, 1 backend project (REST API + DB)
Q3	Dec 2026–Feb 2027	Advanced DP, system design intro, full-stack project	500 total problems, full-stack app deployed, blog/portfolio site
Q4	Mar–May 2027	Mock interviews + applications + LLD/HLD prep	650+ problems, 5 mock interviews, 3 offers

Q1 (Jun–Aug 2026) — DSA Rebuild

Goal: Cover the 70% you're missing. Reach Easy-Medium consistency.

- **Pick one language and stay:** Java (recommended given your background) or Python (faster syntax).
- Topics in order: **Arrays & Strings** (refresh, 1 wk) → **Hashing** (1 wk) → **Two Pointers & Sliding Window** (2 wks) → **Stack/Queue** (1 wk) → **LinkedList** (1 wk) → **Binary Search** (2 wks) → **Recursion & Backtracking** (3 wks).
- Daily: **2 problems on weekdays, 4–5 on weekends.** ~16 problems/week. End of Q1: ~200 problems.
- Use the **NeetCode 150** list as the spine. Don't shop around lists — pick one, finish it.

Q1 Resources

- NeetCode.io (free roadmap + video solutions)
- Striver's A2Z DSA Sheet (Take U Forward, free)
- Book: 'Cracking the Coding Interview' by Gayle McDowell (read selectively)
- LeetCode Premium (optional, ~INR 2700/yr, worth it for company tags)

Q2 (Sep–Nov 2026) — Trees, Graphs, DP intro + First Backend

- Topics: **Binary Trees** (3 wks) → **BST** (1 wk) → **Heaps/Priority Queue** (1 wk) → **Graphs: BFS, DFS, Topo Sort, Union-Find** (4 wks) → **DP intro: 1D, 2D, classic problems** (3 wks).
- **Side project:** Spring Boot REST API for a real use case (URL shortener, expense tracker, task manager). Postgres + JWT auth + deployed on Render/Railway. Public GitHub with good README.
- Start contributing micro-PRs to small open-source projects. Even doc fixes count on resume.

Q3 (Dec 2026–Feb 2027) — Advanced DP, System Design, Full-stack

- Topics: **Advanced DP** (LIS, LCS, knapsack variants, MCM, partition DP — 4 wks) → **Tries** (1 wk) → **Segment Trees / Fenwick (optional)** → **System Design fundamentals** (4 wks: caching, load balancing, DBs, queues, microservices, CAP, consistency models).
- **Full-stack project:** Add a React frontend to your Spring Boot API. Deploy. This is your portfolio centerpiece.
- Begin LLD (Low-Level Design) practice — Parking Lot, Splitwise, BookMyShow design problems. Use 'Design Patterns' notes (you already know 7 from Apex — the principles transfer).

Q3 Resources

- System Design: ByteByteGo YouTube channel, 'Designing Data-Intensive Applications' (Kleppmann — skim, not read cover-to-cover)
- LLD: github.com/prasadgujar/low-level-design-primer
- Mock interviews: Pramp (free), Interviewing.io

Q4 (Mar–May 2027) — Interview Loop

- Target: **product companies** — Atlassian, PhonePe, Razorpay, Swiggy, Zoho, Postman, Freshworks, Browserstack, Hotstar/Disney, mid-tier startups.
- Resume: project links, GitHub stars (if any), measurable backend metrics (latency, throughput) if you have them.
- Apply via referrals (LinkedIn DMs to engineers at target cos — 60% reply rate if your profile is solid).
- Expect: 5–8 interview loops, 3 final rounds, 1–3 offers.

Realistic Outcome (Path B)

Scenario	Probability	CTC Range	Notes
Best case	15%	22–30 LPA	FAANG-adjacent product co., strong DSA + system design + lucky
Expected	35%	12–18 LPA	Mid-tier product co. or fast-growing startup
Floor	30%	8–12 LPA	Service co. with better tech stack (TCS Digital, Infosys SES)

Failure	20%	Stuck or worse	Diluted profile, dropped Salesforce momentum, no SDE offer
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3. Path A vs. Path B — Decision Matrix

Dimension	Path A: SF + GenAI	Path B: SDE Pivot
Time required / week	10–12 hrs	15–20 hrs
Builds on current job?	Yes — strong synergy	No — competes for time
12-mo CTC (expected)	11–14 LPA	12–18 LPA
12-mo CTC ceiling	18–20 LPA	25–30 LPA
Probability of hitting 13–15 LPA	~55%	~35%
Probability of failure (no jump)	~5%	~20%
Long-term ceiling (5 yr)	30–45 LPA (Salesforce architect)	40–80 LPA (senior SDE / EM)
Resilience to AI disruption	Medium — Agentforce is the AI wave in CRM	High — SDE skills are general-purpose
Market saturation (India)	Low — Agentforce talent is scarce	High — SDE supply is huge
Stress level	Moderate	High

4. My Recommendation — Specifically For You

Go with Path A as primary. Layer Path B's DSA grind at 30% intensity.

Concretely, here's what that means:

- **80% of your study time** → Path A (Salesforce certs, Agentforce, GenAI stack, projects).
- **20% of your study time** → LeetCode — **1 problem per day, no exceptions**. Use NeetCode 150.
- Why: the HackerRank technical assessment has a DSA section. Your Cognizant work won't keep DSA sharp. 1 problem/day = ~365 problems in a year = enough to clear most service-co interview filters and many mid-tier product co. screens. It's also a hedge — if Path A stalls, you're not at zero.
- If by Q3 (Dec 2026) you discover you have more bandwidth, escalate DSA to 2–3 problems/day and add system design. You'll have optionality.
- If by Q3 you're behind on Path A, drop DSA entirely and focus.

5. Non-Negotiable Habits

- **Sunday review** — 30 min: what shipped this week, what didn't, why. Adjust next week.
- **Public artifacts** — every project on GitHub, every cert on LinkedIn, 1 LinkedIn post/week from Q2 onwards. Recruiters source from LinkedIn, not from resumes.
- **Network** — connect with 5 Salesforce/GenAI professionals per week on LinkedIn. By month 12 you'll have 200+ industry contacts. Referrals close 40% faster than cold applications.
- **Don't read — build**. If a tutorial doesn't end with you typing code into a real project, you'll forget it in 3 weeks.
- **Sleep 7+ hours**. Sleep-deprived coding produces worse interview performance than no preparation.

6. Things That Will Try to Derail You

- **Project work pressure at Cognizant** — if assigned to a heavy client project, study time will be eaten. Negotiate scope where possible. Prioritize personal projects on weekends.
- **Tutorial hell** — watching videos feels productive. It isn't. Always build in parallel.
- **Comparison spirals** — X cleared Google in 6 months, Y got 25 LPA. Doesn't matter. Run your own race.
- **Burnout at month 6–8** — build in a 1-week deload every quarter. Non-negotiable.
- **Wedding/family season Oct–Dec** — pre-plan around it. Frontload Q2 work in Sep.

7. Checkpoints — Quarterly Self-Audit

End of	Path A check	Path B check
Aug 2026	PD1 cleared? Project 1 on GitHub?	200 LC problems done?
Nov 2026	LWC fluent? Project 2 shipped? Agentforce demo built?	350 LC + 1 backend project?
Feb 2027	Agentforce cert? RAG project deployed? 4 LinkedIn posts?	500 LC + full-stack project deployed?
May 2027	3 offers, >=12 LPA top offer?	3 offers, >=14 LPA top offer?

Final word. Roadmaps don't change careers. Execution does. Pick the path, then run. Check in with me at each quarterly checkpoint — I'll have your context and we can adjust.